

Teaching a new dog old tricks!

LEAKS ARE EVERYWHERE. Leaks are the new norm, honestly. In fact, it's almost impossible to tell which leaks are the results of mistakes and hackers, and which are marketing tools used to build hype. Pretty much anything to do with the entertainment world is what I usually consider to be strategic information sharing, rather than leaks, but ever so often, something big comes along.

Hackers have been after entertainment and gaming companies for years now, and when the stakes are as high as finding and releasing Game of Thrones episodes, there's an unsurprising rise of interest. While companies like HBO must be spending a bomb on safeguarding their content and trying to prevent leaks (especially after being victims of leaks earlier), the interest of hackers and the underground army of leakers and pirates no doubt increases the attention towards them exponentially. Can anything really be secure anymore? Will we ever see the end of leaks? I certainly hope not!

As I write this, the internet is breaking! Well, OK, it's not breaking, but it's blowing up for people above 30, who grew up playing *Half-life* and *Half-life 2*! For those of you who don't know, *Half-life* was my favourite game of all time... until Valve released *Half-life 2*, that is. Then, when Valve went episodic, I applauded them, because I didn't want to wait a decade to get the next *Half-life* installment...

Half-life released in November, 1998, then *Half-life 2* was released in November 2004 (6 years later). Then came *Half-life 2: Episode 1*, in June 2006, and finally *Half-life 2: Episode 2* in October 2007. Next month will actually be a decade since we were promised *Half-life 2: Episode 3*. I shouldn't have been so quick to applaud the episodic format...

Although not really a "leak", Marc Laidlaw's supposed fan fiction (<http://dgit.in/HLEP3Leak>) might be the closest we get to *Episode 3*, ever. Or not... I still have hope!

For those of you who don't know (or don't care to know), Marc Laidlaw was a writer for Valve, and worked on the *Half-life* and *Half-life 2* franchises. All the excitement surrounding his "fanfiction" blog post called "Epistle 3", is because those of us who follow *Half-life* news

know that it is the rough plotline for *Episode 3* that he "leaked".

While only Laidlaw knows why he posted what he did... because his plot matches with previously leaked concept art, people like me who have waited a decade for some closure, finally find some in this. I now know what would have happened in one of the most addictive game storylines in the past two decades. Call me a useless sap, but I'm still hoping that the popularity of this fanfiction, or leak, or whatever it is, will show Valve that there are hordes of people who would still happily pay good money to buy games that continue the *Half-life* story.

Something similar happened when someone asked Bill Gates on a Reddit AMA about continuing the *Age of Empires* (AoE) series of games. The sheer popularity of that one single question might have spurred someone into action (or perhaps action might even have been ordered by Gates himself), because we now know that not only is the older AoE game getting a visual upgrade as *Age of Empires: Definitive Edition*, a new *Age of Empires IV* game (<http://dgit.in/AOE4Announce>) is in the pipeline. *AoE III* was released in 2005, and thus it's already been 12 years between games. (And don't you dare write to me to point out all the AoE spin-offs that were released after 2005, because they were just not as good).

PS: Don't try asking about Half-life 3 on reddit though, because every mention has a bot reply and set the mock release date one month in the future. The highest I've seen it go is October 3510!

And it's not just games, but movies as well. We seem to have come full circle with entertainment in general, where the hottest things are stuff from yesteryear! Heck, all of the remakes and the making of old comics into movies, etc., seem to be the only good entertainment these days. It's almost like culture decided to do a rewind, because there was nowhere to move forward to. Not that I'm complaining, of course...

Write in or contact me on social media, because I'd love to hear about your favourite games and movies from yesteryear that you think need a modern reboot. Maybe we can engineer some "leaks" or start petitions to get the developers or moviemakers to take notice? 



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